

# 1000–900 BCE



In the mid-10th century BCE, during the reign of King Solomon, Megiddo (in modern Israel) was an important Israelite fortress and administrative center.

**IN THE 10TH CENTURY BCE, THE PERIOD OF DECLINE** in the major powers of Western Asia continued. Egypt, Babylon, and Assyria had weakened, enabling the rise of the short-lived but historically significant **Kingdom of Israel**. The Israelites were Semitic-speaking pastoralists who, according to the Bible, migrated into the land of Canaan in the 1200s BCE. There, they came into conflict with the local Philistines and Canaanites. Around 1000 BCE **King David** (r. 1006–965 BCE) **united the Israelite tribes** and established his capital at **Jerusalem**. David's son **Solomon** (r. c. 965–928 BCE) increased Israelite territory and built a magnificent palace and temple in the capital, but on his death the kingdom split in two. Eventually

## Etched in gold

This golden plaque showing the protective wedjat eye symbol dates from the reign of Psusennes I of the 21st dynasty, when Egypt was divided.



# 900–800 BCE



The jaguar featured in many Mesoamerican and South American religions. Here it is depicted in a stone carving from Chavin de Huántar.

## SHALMANESER III (858–824 BCE)



In the 9th century BCE, King Shalmaneser III of Assyria greatly expanded his empire, with campaigns against Mesopotamian tribes, Israel and Judah, Syria, Urartu, and Anatolia. This black limestone obelisk commemorates his deeds and those of his commander-in-chief, Dayyan-Assur. It details, in cuneiform, the enforced tributes paid by the people he conquered.

Israel and, later, Judah became part of the Assyrian Empire.

Meanwhile, **Assyria** began to reemerge as a **major power in Mesopotamia**. King Ashur-dan II (r. 934–912 BCE) boosted agriculture, bringing prosperity. His successor Adad-nirari II increased Assyria's territory, regaining lands that had been held by the Middle Assyrian Empire in the 13th century BCE.

## THE OLMEC CULTURE CONTINUED TO DEVELOP IN MESOAMERICA

In the 9th century BCE. After San Lorenzo was destroyed in c. 900 BCE, **La Venta** to the northeast became the **main Olmec center**. This larger settlement was dominated by a 111 ft (34 m) high pyramid, the forerunner of Mayan temples. The Olmecs also devised a script of **glyphs**—the first in the region. Their influence spread across Mesoamerica, impacting on other cultures that were starting to emerge at this time—the **Zapotecs** and the **Maya**.

In eastern North America, the **Adena culture** was developing in the Ohio Valley. It was characterized by ritual earthworks and burial mounds containing objects of fine craftsmanship.

Far to the south, the **Chavin culture** had appeared in the Peruvian Andes by c. 1200 BCE and spread to the coast. The Chavin

were **skilled engineers** and **architects** who built canals and leveled slopes for farming and construction. The main settlement, **Chavin de Huántar**, was high in the Andes, and seems to have been a pilgrimage center for a cult of supernatural beings that were part-human, part-animal. The main god, the “Staff God,” is usually depicted with fangs.

In **Europe**, **iron** was gradually **replacing bronze** as the metal of choice for tools and weapons. The area around **Hallstatt** in Austria became a center for an early Iron Age culture that developed from the Urnfield culture (see 1200 BCE). Hallstatt chieftains dominated local salt mining and ironworking. They lived in hilltop forts and were buried with rich grave goods.

During the 9th century BCE, the **Phoenicians** were becoming a major power in the Mediterranean. Their trading ships, previously confined to the eastern sea, now



## Grave goods

This Iron Age brooch was discovered in a grave at Hallstatt in Austria. The type of jewelry found suggests that a woman was buried there.

plied the western Mediterranean. Colonies were set up in Cadiz, in Spain, on the Balearic Islands, and, most notably, on the North African coast at Carthage (in modern Tunisia). Through this trading network, the Phoenician **alphabet** became known throughout the Mediterranean.

In Western Asia, the **Neo-Assyrian Empire** began to expand, and, one by one, Israel, Judah, and the small states of nearby Syria and Phoenicia were brought under Assyrian control.

## KEY

- Assyria
- Egypt
- Phoenician colonies
- Phoenician city-states
- Greek colonies
- Greek city-states
- Emerging Etruscan city-states



## Mediterranean region

This map of the Mediterranean region in the 8th century BCE shows the colonies established by the dominant civilizations of the period, including the Phoenicians and Greeks.

